Arthashastra is categorical that the Atavika, 'living in their own territory, are many in number and brave, fight openly, seize and ruin countries, having the same characteristics as a king.'[41] Ashoka's edict, threatening and cajoling this group, shows the persistence of powerful enemies within the ambit of empire. The message speaks of various kings and people beyond his frontiers and those within his territories:

> And such a conquest has been achieved by the Beloved of the Gods not only here (in his dominions) but also in the territories bordering (on his dominions), as far away as (at the distance of) six hundred yojanas, (where) the Yavana king named Antiyoka (is ruling and where), beyond (the kingdom of) the said Antiyoka, four other kings named Tulamaya, Antikeni, Maka and Alikasudara (are also ruling), (and) towards the south, where the Colas and Pandyas (are living), as far as Tamraparni.
>
> Likewise here in the dominions of His Majesty, (the Beloved of the Gods)—in (the countries of) the Yavanas and Kambojas, of the Nabhakas and Nabhapanktis, of the Bhoja-paitryanikas (i.e. hereditary or tribal Bhojas) and of the Andhras and Paulindas, everywhere (people) are conforming to the instructions in Dharma (imparted) by the Beloved of the Gods.
>
> Even where the envoys of the Beloved of the Gods have not penetrated, there too men have heard of the practices of the Dharma and the ordinances issued and the instructions in Dharma (imparted) by the Beloved of the Gods, (and) are conforming to Dharma (and) will continue to conform to it.[42]

The recitation of these names has a pattern to it. The kings and people mentioned either lived beyond the western borders of the Mauryan empire or across its southern rim as far as Sri Lanka. These were powerful independent rulers and polities and speaking about his conquest of them through dhamma was Ashoka's way of drawing attention to his sphere of influence.[43] We see a victorious king announcing his authority over other polities and rulers by unusually pacific means.[44] Some of them may well have been states over which an expanding Mauryan empire had territorial designs. Possibly, Mauryan envoys now deputed there would have had to explain Ashoka's change of heart. The hope may also have been expressed